

Photograph by **REHAN KHAN**

> **"THERE WERE DAYS WHEN EVEN TWO MEALS WERE A LUXURY... SOMETIMES I HAD TO SURVIVE ON PAV AND CHUTNEY"**
>
> **SANDEEP DABHADE**

in packaging materials, soon adding manufacturing after securing a second-hand machine. Overcoming cash flow issues and a ballooning debt burden, Dabhade secured a Rs 11 lakh working capital loan from the non-profit business mentoring programme BYST (Bharatiya Yuva Shakti Trust).

But a week after clearing his loans, the country went into COVID lockdown. Dabhade, though, continued his work. Even as orders slowed down, Dabhade, guided by his mentor, Milind Pohnerkar, held on to his five-member team, paid salaries on time, and shouldered the overheads himself. The post-COVID phase was good, and he eventually landed Hindustan Unilever supplier Food & Inns Ltd as a major client. Meanwhile, at his unit, he introduced good manufacturing practices (GMP), got ISO certification, and introduced structured planning.

By 2024-25, Eco Pack, now renamed Phoenix Industries, had grown to two units and was employing some 50 people, nearly half of them women. Ten machines run in two 12-hour shifts, serving clients in Pune, Chakan, Solapur, Nashik, Nanded and Waluj. Phoenix packaging has found a place in the pharma, food, electronics and auto sectors.

In 2024, he also returned to his roots with a new venture—processing sugarcane into chemical-free jaggery on his farmland. Production is now up to 500 kg daily, and interest from a US-based entrepreneur has pushed him to refine the product to meet export standards. Dabhade's dream project is an agro-processing hub in Jalna, offering farmers end-to-end solutions such as improved market access and shelf life for produce. ■